



INDIANS ARE FIRMLY hooked on to their mobile phones. From buying vegetables to studying online, from watching videos and making reels to filling up job applications, they use it for almost everything. It shows in the data.

An average Indian cell phone user consumes more than 19 gigabytes (GB) of data per month, the highest in the world. Nearly 80% of the country's population owns a mobile phone, which works out to a whopping 1.13 billion handsets. And data consumption is expected to jump manifold because of the increased adoption of data-intensive technologies like artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning that require a lot of computational power.

With all that data flowing around, India Inc. is rushing to build the conduits to help this new oil reach the farthest corners of the country. It is investing heavily in data centres to make the most of this opportunity. Global real estate services and investment firm CBRE believes that the value of India's data centre market will soar from \$4.35 billion in 2021 to a projected \$10.09 billion by 2027.

That has forced established players in this space like CtrlS Datacenters and Yotta to increase their capacity to fend off challengers big and small, from conglomerates like the Adani Group and Reliance Industries to relatively smaller entrants like Anant Raj Limited.

The government, too, is working actively to put India at the forefront of this development. It has been promoting data centres and localised data storage by classifying them as essential infrastructure, like roads and energy, also keeping in mind the emerging geopolitical situation. The government's ₹10,000-crore AI initiative will be instrumental in creating a network of high-performance data centres available for lease to industry stakeholders, enabling them to train and develop AI models effectively.

This scramble has been sparked by the dearth of data centres in India in comparison with developed countries. Information available with *datacentermap.com*, a global data centre database, shows that India, the fifth-largest economy, has just 245 data centres compared with 2,987 in the US.

Such an increase in data centre capacity will inevi-

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ROHAN SHETH
HEAD-COLOLOCATION
& DATA CENTRE
SERVICES, YOTTA

"The data localisation standards and the government's boost to infrastructure development [have led] to the growing favourability of India among major global data centre operators"



ASHIM SARIN
DIRECTOR
& COO,
ANANT RAJ LTD

"The Indian data centre market is projected to expand at a CAGR of 18% from 2024 to 2029. Despite consuming 30% of the world's data, India currently has only 3% of the global data centre capacity"